

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Pentecost 7
Another Kind of Freedom ~ The Heart of Service
19 July 2026

Preaching: LVF
Worship Leading: ML & ...
Dr. Jaebon Hwang, guest organist

Strips of paper in programs for prayers

Organ Prelude-Concert

Prelude and Fugue in B Major, op. 7, no. 1, Marcel Dupré (1886-1971)
St. Francis of Assisi preaching to the birds, Franz Liszt (1811-1886); arr. Camille
Saint-Saëns (1835-1921)
Prélude, Nadia Boulanger (1887-1979)
Grand Chœur Dialogue, Eugène Gigout (1844-1925)

Dr. Jaebon Hwang, *Guest Organist*

Chiming of the Hour

[Michael and ... center chancel]

Welcome

ML

Words of Gathering

ML & ...

Through little acts of kindness –
the healing powers that lie within a smile,
and the miracles worked by gentle words of praise –
we touch and change the human face of this world.

Only by the power of the human heart
does misery turn to beauty,
despair to new life,
and the killing weight of endless suffering
become the freedom of possibility.

And life calls us – once more –
to celebrate its presence with love,
the deep and burning kind of love
that costs so much.

May we find within our own hearts
the power of that love waiting to be spilled
freely and lavishly

in every place
we might find need.
This world is ours to serve and to heal.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

***Hymn of Gathering** *Holy, Wondrous Mystery, Birthing All Creation* NICAEA
• [LYRICS \(OW\)](#)
• [PDF](#)

Holy wondrous mystery, birthing all creation,
Every day your songs arise from nature's harmony.
Holy, wondrous mystery, breath of our formation,
Source of all life throughout infinity.

Holy wondrous mystery, one in all things dwelling,
Everywhere in everyone you bring divinity.
Holy, sacred presence, loving and compelling,
Living and moving through eternity.

Holy wondrous mystery, darkness magnifies you,
In the darkened depths of soil you root and sprout and thrive
Holy, spacious darkness, moon and sun shine through you.
Stars on your canvas bring the skies to life.

Holy wondrous mystery, birthing all creation,
All your works resound in praise from earth and sky and sea.
Holy wondrous mystery, glorious revelation,
Song of all life throughout infinity.

[Michael center chancel]

***Prayer of Awareness** ML

Please join me in prayer...

O God, in this, our gathering time,
may our hearts be open to the stirring
of holiness.

May it cause us to know grace and love
in those places where
seeds of judgment were sown.

May it allow us to soothe our pain-filled
memories with peace.

May it help us to experience joy
in the divine presence
of all our gathered siblings
from near and far.

*On this day, as we open our hearts to the stirring of holiness
may we know your grace and love
in this sacred space and time -
and then - may all people across the world,
inhabit these gifts in the days to come.
Amen and Amen.*

[All turn towards choir]

***Introit**

[... to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer**

Let us pray together this Lord's Prayer, adapted by enfleshed...

*Creator of us all,
who dwells within and beyond,
Sacred is your name.
May your holy vision for collective flourishing
come to fruition among us.
May your dreams of justice, love, compassion, and
connection be enfleshed on earth.
Provide us today with what we need to be nourished
in body, soul, and heart.
Forgive us for the harm we cause as we seek to
forgive those who have harmed us.
Lead us away from everything that destroys and
liberate us from the hands of evil.
For you are the ultimate source of hope.
Your power-with exceeds all power-over.
Your presence incites eternal wonder.
All praise to you, our comfort and our strength.
Amen and Amen!*

[enfleshed/adpt/lvf]

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.

World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Michael center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

ML

There is no greater service that we offer
than to heal the sick,
to clothe the naked,
to find water for those that thirst,
to bind up the broken-hearted –
much is asked of us
only because we know, in our depths,
that we are capable.

As we fill ourselves
with the gifts of peace in this hour,
may we also fill our hearts to overflowing
with an urgent need
to do the work to which we are called.

Together, may we overflow in our zeal
for a realm of justice and peace,
of equity for all.

May the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

Please be seated

[...to lectern]

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition *from Philippians*

Do nothing out of selfish ambition or vain conceit. Rather, in humility value others above yourselves, not looking to your own interests but each of you to the interests of the others.

For this witness of the ancients...
Thanks be to God!

[Jaebon short transition Michael center chancel]

Prayers with the People

ML

Invitation to Silence and Prayer
We are held by an awesome beauty.
Above, below, and surrounding us

is the constant presence of Life.
It calls to us,
urges us beyond our own
understandings of ourselves,
places before us images of its own limitlessness,
so that we may see, in its reflection, our own.

In this time of silence,
may we sense the Life we bring to this place
honor and delight in it
and know it as that within which
we find our meaning.

May we find its energizing pull, never coercing, only inviting us to deeper ways of being.

Invitation to write prayers

Let us now be in silence, together.

Silence

[Jaebon transition out of silence as people come forward to offer prayers and light candles]

[Michael center chancel when everyone seated]

Prayer of Our Hearts

Let us pray:

Creator and Creative God, on this day, we long to live in harmony with all creation,
to daily find ways to heal our world,
her peoples and all that share life upon her.
For we know that doing so is to participate in your ever-flowing river of healing,
is to co-create the universe as you intend it, full of wholeness, justice, and peace for all.

Because of your love, may all that confines and hinders that flourishing within and
among us fall away.

***Because of your love, empower us to lose ourselves into this life with devotion and
desire, that we may find our true selves in service, compassion, and mercy.***

Because of your love, may we know the ways that make for peace,
in our souls and in this world.

***And then, O God, help love to so inhabit our world,
that we will give our lives to its path both this day,
and forever more.
Amen and Amen.***

[jrichardson/adptlvf]

[Jaebon transition for choir]

Meditation Anthem

[Christoph transition LVF to pulpit, choir to seats]

Sermon

The Heart of Service

LVF

[Jaebon transition ... to lectern, choir to places]

Invitation to Generosity

Each week when we gather, we are reminded that it is in community,
we come to understand that the well-being of all life is interconnected.

In this time, we have the opportunity to turn from individualism and self-sufficiency and
practice solidarity with one another, in joy and in struggle.

By sharing what we have, striving for collective freedom, and giving and receiving in
mutual love, we honor God's intentions for life and create openings for the flourishing we
desire.

We show our gratitude for these things, and so much more, by giving from our resources
to ensure this community is always and forever, available to all people.

Today, we invite your offerings for our Community Gardens & Urban Farm at the
Cathedral. **[Expand]**

You will find information for online giving in your programs and on the screen if you are
with us online. If you are here in person today, our Hospitality Team will come forward
to collect any gifts you'd like to share.

Offertory Anthem

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[... to lectern toward end of doxology]

***Offering Prayer**

Holy One,

Today, we remember all who have
brought your gifts to us.

We give thanks for those who cloak
themselves in humility,
and, who, through their service,
show us a more excellent way.

In these coming days, O God,
may we learn from them
and may we too, offer our gifts
to those who need us the most.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us.

Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

[Laura & Michael center chancel]

Life at First Church

ML & LVF

Words of Blessing

LVF

May the Mystery we call God
keep alive in each of us
the search for Love that is real;
Love that helps us live more joyful lives;
Love that gives us a fuller
meaning to life and the events of life;
Love that serves and shares and
insists on what might yet be.

*Bring us , O God, the goodness that flows
from your heart of Love,
and may we be expanded in heart and soul
by that Love.
This is our prayer.*

Choral Response

***Hymn for the Journey**

In the Midst of All Our Living

NETTLETON

In the midst of every blessing, may our hearts be filled with grace.
Streams of goodness, ever flowing call for songs of highest praise.
May our words be filled with gratitude; may our glad hearts humble be.
As a holder of a blessing, may we share it gratefully.

In the midst of every trial, may our hearts be filled with grace.
Streams of comfort, ever flowing, call for songs of highest praise.
May we find the strength within us; may we sense it everywhere.
As we face what must be handled, may we find truth we can share.

In the midst of all our living, may our hearts be filled with grace.
Streams of goodness ever flowing call for songs of highest praise.
May we seek and find encouragement; may our choices worthy be.
As we journey on together, may we know integrity.

-Lyrics by Scott Kearns, 2008, inspired by Robert Robinson, 1758

[Michael center chancel]

Postlude

Nicaea, arr. Craig Phillips (b. 1961)

Dr. Jaebon Hwang, *Guest Organist*

Inside The Music